



A great tail

A whale's tail is made up of two tail flukes, or sections, that are joined at the center. Unlike a fish's tail, a whale's tail lies flat. This is the whale's "propeller," which forces it forward.

What a leap!

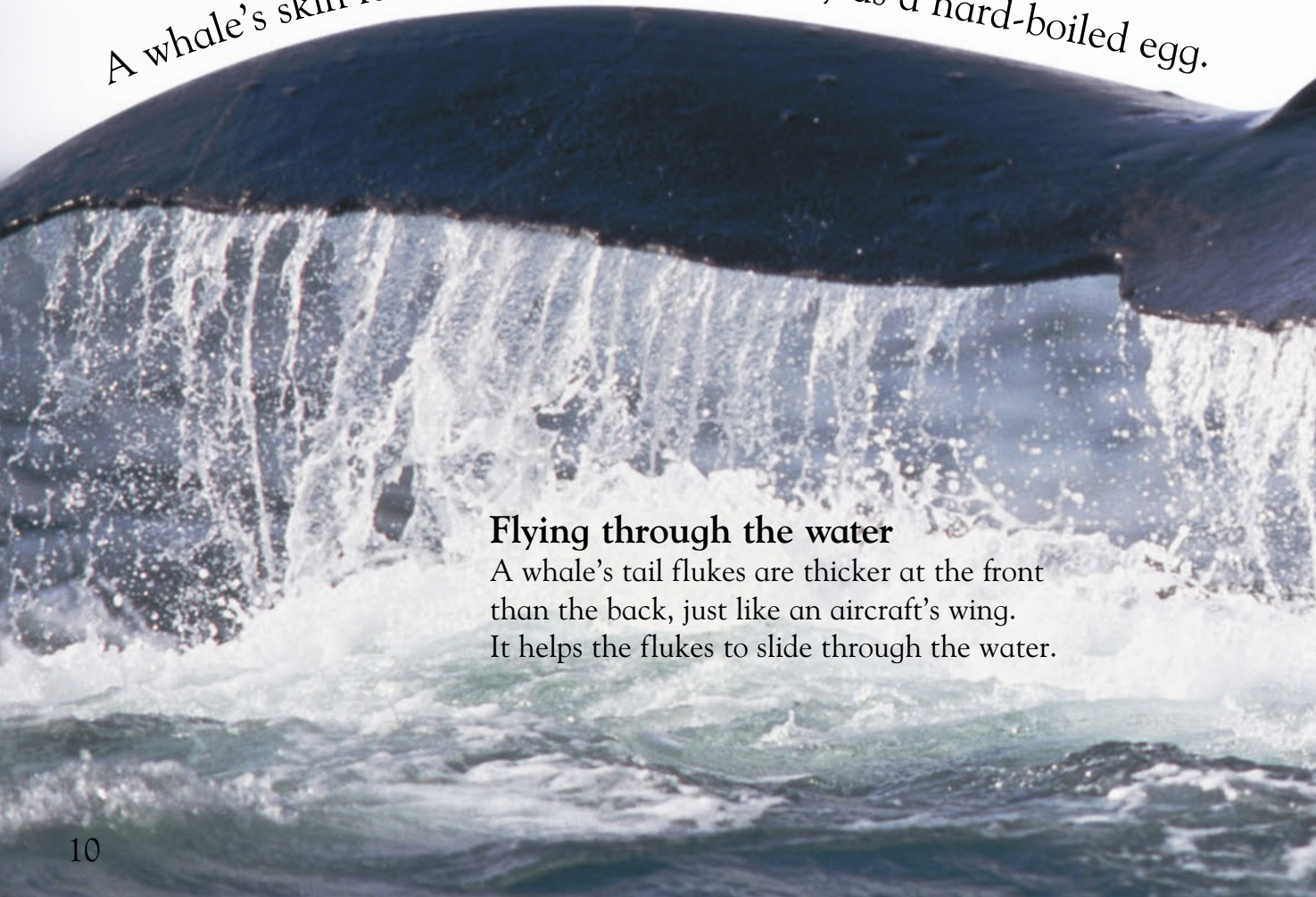
The sheer power of the tail's muscle is shown by the fact that many whales and dolphins can launch themselves out of the water.



Listen up!

A whale will sometimes slap its tail flukes against the water's surface. It is thought that this may be a form of communication.

A whale's skin feels as smooth and rubbery as a hard-boiled egg.



Flying through the water

A whale's tail flukes are thicker at the front than the back, just like an aircraft's wing. It helps the flukes to slide through the water.